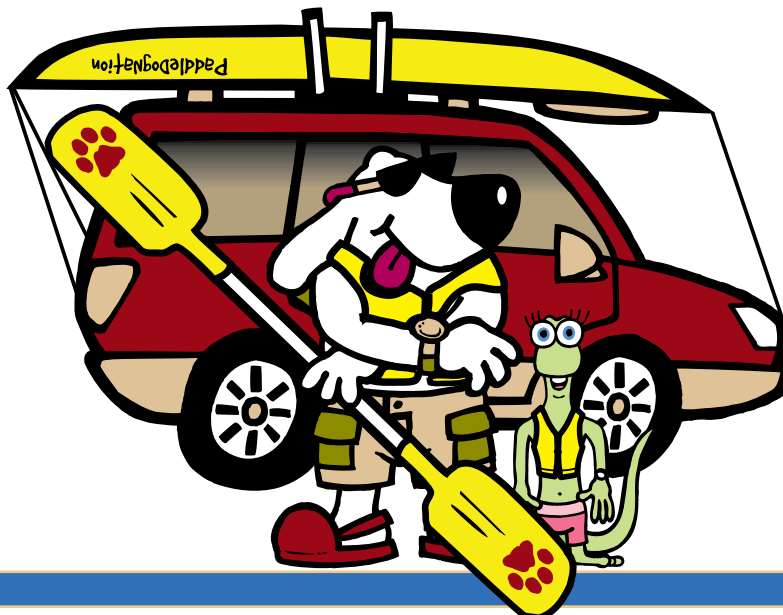


The Beginner's Guide to Canoe & Kayak Paddling



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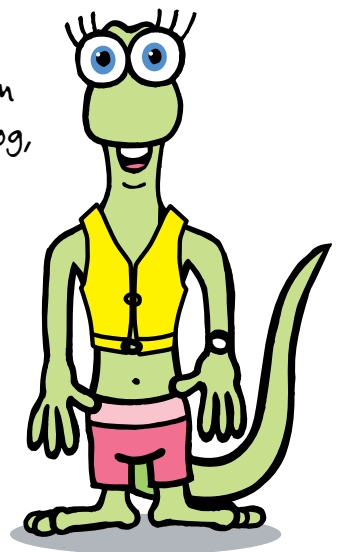
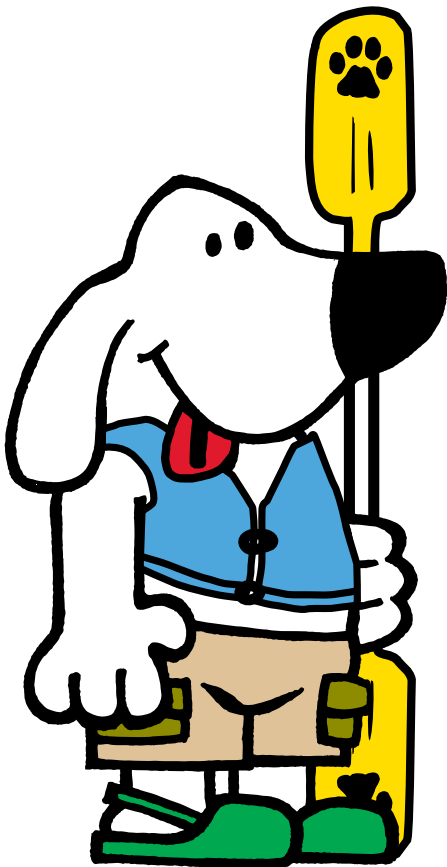
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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

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Welcome to the water!

You've just bought a canoe or kayak, now what? Well, the first thing you should do is read through this Beginner's Guide. It will answer a lot of the questions you have about your new boat and the basics of paddling. The second thing you should do, before you set out on your own, is to take a beginner's paddling course! A certified instructor will teach you the in's and out's of basic paddling so that you can enjoy your time on the water. *More importantly, he or she will teach you how to be safe on the water!* (See the sidebar for more information on finding a certified trainer near you.)

The guide is organized in five major sections, plus an introduction to paddling jargon, and the pros and cons of kayaks and canoes. We'll cover paddling gear. (And there is a lot of paddling gear!) Next we'll go over planning your trip. You'll find that once you get in the habit of planning a paddling trip, it will become second nature to you. Planning will save you time and worry. Then we get into the basics of paddling techniques and safety. Finally we talk briefly about care and maintenance of your boat.

Along the way, Boggle, the official Spokesdog of PaddleDogNation.com, and his paddling partner, Sally Mander, will offer you paddling tips and hints. You can also visit PaddleDogNation.com to download the checklists and other forms you find in this booklet, along with much more.

Happy paddlin'!



Boggle and his paddling pal, Sally Mander

Take a Paddling Course!

Although this guide is written for beginning paddlers, it cannot take the place of a class taught by a certified instructor, nor is it meant to. This guide is designed to introduce you to the basics of flat water paddling. Before you get on the water, take an introductory course from a certified instructor. Your local paddling shop may offer instruction or may be able to refer you to an instructor. You can also check with any local paddling clubs in your area. **The American Canoe Association (www.americancanoe.org)** can also refer you to instructors.

Look for the cursor for links to more information online! Just click on the link and your browser will open automatically.

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Paddling Jargon

Before you get started, let's take a couple minutes to go over a few definitions. Canoes and kayaks are relatively simple crafts, but there are some technical terms you should become familiar with. As your experience grows, you'll learn more, but here are the terms you need to know to get started.

Bow: The front end of the boat.

Coaming: The rim of a kayak's cockpit, which has a raised lip that a sprayskirt can be attached to.

Eskimo Roll: Developed by Eskimos, who are honored by the name used today. The Eskimo Roll is the act of up-righting a cap-sized kayak without having to leave the boat. The paddler uses the paddle and body movements in the water to roll the kayak right-side up. It is also known as rolling and there are multiple ways to execute this roll.

Lead Boat: The lead boat paddles ahead of other canoes or kayaks in a group. Usually the most experienced paddler.

PFD (Personal Flotation Device): Also referred to as a Life Jacket or Life Vest. It is required that any vessel on the water must have at least one PFD for each person in the vessel. In most states it is required that children must wear a PFD while on water.

Port: The left side of a boat, as perceived by a person on the boat facing the bow (or front) of the boat. Port is not synonymous with "left." When facing the stern (or rear) of the boat, the port will be on your right side.

Portage: The act of carrying the boat and supplies to the water, from the water, or around obstacles in the water.

Put-in: The place you put your boat into the water.

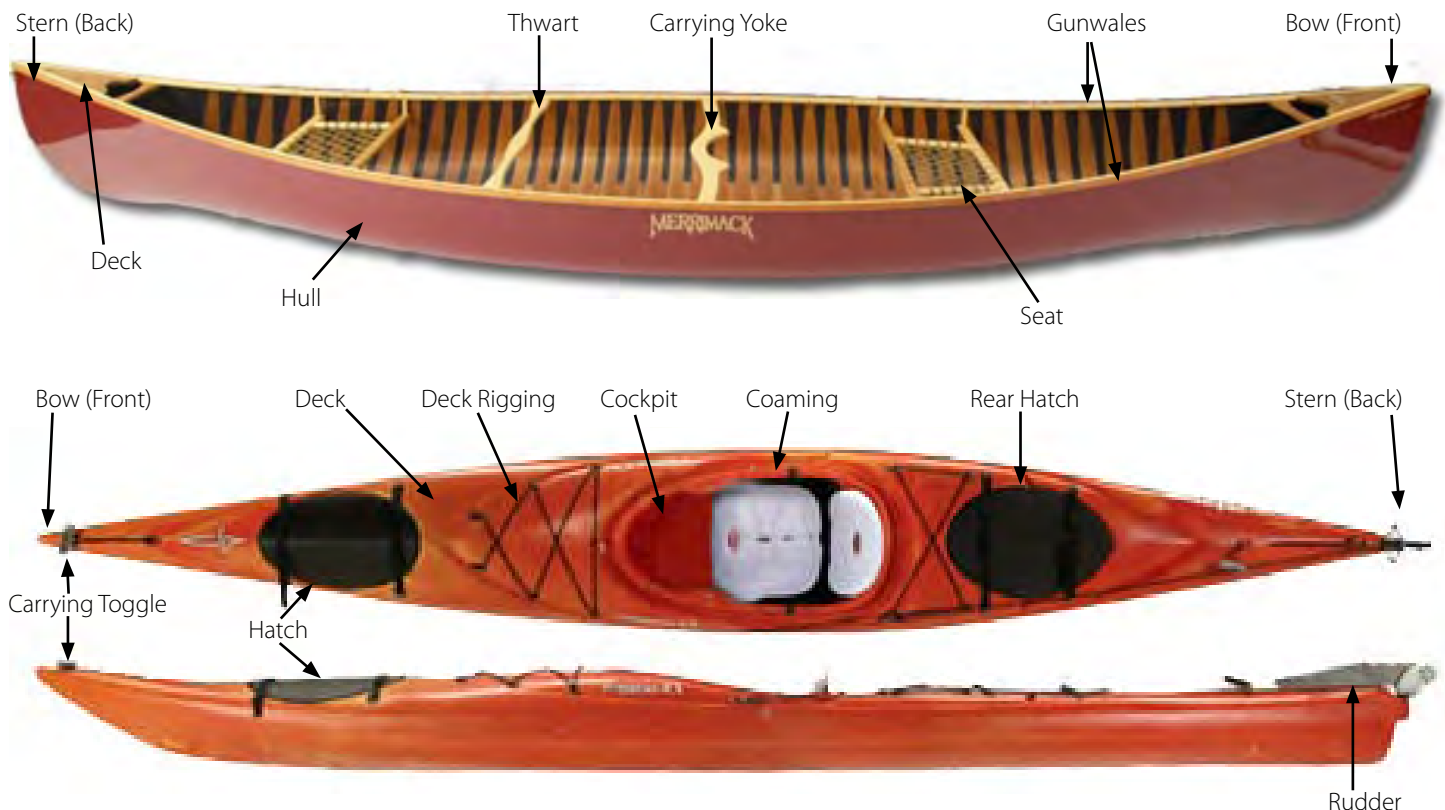
Starboard: The right side of a boat, as perceived by a person on the boat facing the bow (or front) of the boat. Starboard is not synonymous with "right." When facing the stern (or rear) of the boat, the starboard will be on your left side.

Stern: The back of the boat.

Sweep Boat: The last boat in a group of paddlers. Usually assigned to keep track of stragglers.

Take-out: The place at which you take the boat out of the water.

Thwart: A support structure that stretches across the width of the canoe.





Which Boat is For You?

Canoe or Kayak?

Choosing the right type of boat is a crucial first step to safe paddling. Are you going for a day trip or a longer adventure? Will you be paddling on a lake or river? Bringing lots of gear or traveling light? These are some of the questions you need to ask yourself before you start planning your paddle. To help you answer them, we've compared some very general traits of both kayaks and canoes below for the beginner paddler. (As you become a more experienced and proficient paddler, you will be able to expand where and how you paddle in your favorite boat.) Your best bet is to find a reputable dealer who will take the time talk with you about your paddling needs and show you a variety of boat models that match them. You should also test paddle a variety of boats as well. Many dealers offer test paddle programs as well as test paddle events.

Canoe

- Sit or kneel to paddle
- Good on flat water
- Usually carries multiple people
- Larger carrying capacity
- Easier to carry
- Easier to stay dry
- Harder to paddle straight
- Usually slower

Kayak

- Sit to paddle
- Good on flat or rough water
- Usually carries one person
- Smaller carrying capacity
- Harder to carry
- Harder to stay dry
- Easier to paddle straight
- Usually faster





Paddling Gear

What's It Good For?

If air and water temperature, when added together, are less than 120° F, or if the water is 60° F or less, you should use a wetsuit when paddling.

Check your lifejacket for wear and tear before you put it on. Broken zippers, frayed straps, and torn fabric make lifejackets dangerous! **And put it on... it won't work if you don't wear it!**

Boggle says...

Never drink river water! You never know what's in it.



Safe paddling takes a lot of gear, and the know-how to use it right. This list isn't complete, but it's a pretty good start.

Some Gear you must have

Personal Flotation Device (PFD) aka 'Lifejacket': A properly fitted PFD will keep you afloat indefinitely. Your PFD should be worn at all times when on the water.

Bailer and/or bilge pump: A device that gets water out of your boat, usually a scoop (kayakers can also use a sponge). Kayakers also use a small, hand-powered pump to get water out of the cockpit.

Drinking Water & Snack: Keep a supply of drinking water close at hand, and take a couple of power bars or a bag of trail mix along, even if you're bringing lunch.

Drybag: A waterproof bag for storing gear.

First-Aid Kit: Always carry a well-stocked first-aid kit in a waterproof container or drybag, and hope you don't need it.

Flashlight: A small, waterproof flashlight makes a great emergency signal at night. Make sure the batteries are fresh before you leave, though.

Paddle aka 'Oar': You use the paddle to move your boat; without a paddle, your boat won't be able to go. You should also carry a spare paddle.

Paddle Float (kayak): A floating cushion, either inflatable or made of foam, that slips onto a paddle blade and turns your paddle into a temporary outrigger. It helps you get back in your 'yak from the water.

Sprayskirt (kayak): A stretch of water-resistant fabric, usually nylon or neoprene, that attaches around both the paddler's waist and the kayak cockpit and keeps water out of the boat. If you use one, be sure you know how to attach it properly and how to detach it quickly.

Sunscreen: Always carry sunscreen. Remember that you can get sunburned even on overcast or foggy days.

Water Shoes: Special shoes that are designed to be worn in the water. They have good tread, won't get waterlogged, and will protect your feet from injury from sticks and rocks. Do not go barefooted, or wear open-toed shoes when paddling.

Whistle: Keep a whistle attached to your lifejacket to signal for help (or to 'honk' at the boat ahead of you).

Drybags



Inflatable Paddle Float



Foam Paddle Float





Paddling Gear (continued)

More Essential and Optional Gear you should have

Bug Repellent: If you're paddling outdoors, you need bug spray.

Cell Phone: As long as you're not too deep in the wilderness and can still get a signal, cell phones are an easy way to call for help.

Clothing: The wrong kind of clothing for the weather and environment can be uncomfortable or even fatal. Consider things like air and water temperature, humidity, skin exposure (to sun, bugs, vegetation, etc.), and weight. And don't forget to pack a dry change of clothes for the after-paddle trip home!

Drybox aka 'Pelican Box': A waterproof hardshell box for storing gear.

Emergency Kit: Bring a small drybag with basic emergency gear – waterproof matches, a signal mirror, a waterproof flashlight, a space blanket – every time you paddle.

Flares: If you're camping or paddling in a remote location, you should bring a few flares with you.

Glasses Strap: A strap that attaches to the frame of your glasses (or sunglasses) and goes around the back of your neck so that they won't fall in the water if they slip off of your nose.

Global Positioning System (GPS): A GPS system lets you know where you've been, where you are, and where you're going.

Hat aka 'Cap': It keeps the sun off of your head.

Helmet: If you're likely to hit rough waters, wear a helmet.

Kneeling Pad (canoe): A pad, usually waterproof foam, that canoeists use to cushion their knees while paddling.

Knife: A small utility knife can be a lot more useful than you think. Just make sure it's clean and dry each time you stow it.

Paddle Leash (kayak): A rope or line, sometimes elastic, that attaches to both your paddle and your boat so that you won't lose your paddle if you drop it in the water.



Visit the North American Safe Boating Campaign's **Wear It!** website for more information on PFD's.
(<http://www.safeboatingcampaign.net>)

Personal Flotation Device (PFD)



PFD's for Everyone!

There are five types of PFD's, and each type is designed for different uses. Paddlers should probably use either a Type III PFD, which is the most comfortable for continuous wear, or a Type II PFD, which can turn an unconscious paddler face up in calm waters.

Since you will be wearing your PFD a lot, this is one piece of gear that it is worth investing money in. Make sure it fits snugly, but comfortably for the type of paddling you will be doing. There are now PFD's designed especially for women that are comfortable for a full day of paddling.

Inflatables & Hybrids

The Coast Guard has approved inflatable PFD's and PFD's that are hybrid combinations of a traditional PFD with an inflatable bladder. CO2 cartridges are used to inflate these PFD's. They are for use by adults only, and are less bulky to wear.

US Coast Guard PFD Classifications

Type I: Designed for offshore use, where rescue may be slow in coming. Keeps most unconscious wearers face up.

Type II: Near shore usage, where there is good chance of a quick rescue. Keeps some unconscious wearers face up.

Type III: Good for conscious users on inland waters. Designed for general boating activity.

Type IV: A throwable flotation device. A good back up to a wearable PFD.

Type V: Special usage PFD. Performance level will be indicated on label.



Paddling Gear

What's It Good For? (Optional Gear cont.)

Sprayskirt



Throw Bag



Many boat retailers carry pre-assembled safety packages. When buying a new boat, it's a good opportunity to go ahead and get everything you need.

Repair Kit: Keep a kit on hand with duct tape, sealant, and waterproof tape for minor repairs.

Rescue Sling aka 'Rescue Stirrup' (kayak): A loop of rope or webbing that can be attached to a paddle float or kayak and then acts as a step to assist you in re-entering your kayak.

River Map: With a good map of the waterways you're paddling, you'll never get lost. As long as you also have a compass.

Saw: If you're paddling in waters with a lot of branches or logs in them, consider bringing a small folding saw.

Signal Mirror: A small mirror can make a good daytime emergency signal.

Space Blanket: A thin sheet of metal-coated plastic designed to reflect your body heat back at you. Since they fold up into a very small, very light package, you can easily include one in your emergency kit.

Spraycover (canoe) aka 'Spraydeck': A stretch of water-resistant fabric, usually nylon or neoprene, that attaches around both the paddler's waist and the canoe's outer hull and keeps water out of the boat. If you use one, be sure you know how to attach it properly and how to detach it quickly.

Sunglasses: Keep a pair around, just in case. Sunlight on water can be blinding.

Throw Bag: A floating bag attached to a length of rope that you can throw to a capsized paddler and haul them in.

Throw Rope & Throw (or Rescue) Bag: A rope, up to 70 feet, that you can throw to other paddlers in their boats or on the shore. The Throw Bag is a floating bag that contains the throw rope and keeps it on the surface of the water.

Thwart Bag (canoe): An easily accessible bag that attaches to a thwart (see page 2) for storing frequently used gear (and water and snacks).

Tow Line: A flexible rope or bungee that attaches to your boat and lets you tow another paddler's boat. For use by experienced paddlers only.

Towels: Keep a few big towels in your vehicle so you can get dry fast.

Water Gloves: A pair of water gloves can prevent a nasty case of blisters. Be sure they're breathable, flexible, and have a good grip.

Waterproof Matches: Bring a few all-weather matches with you, just in case. A good lighter works, too.

Paddle Leash



Always pack a first-aid kit.



Paddling Gear

Packing Your Canoe

Although canoes can carry a lot of equipment, you should never bring more than you need on a paddle, especially if you're going to portage your canoe for any real distance. Remember, you'll be carrying all that gear as well as the canoe! Plus, the lighter the load, the better your canoe will handle on the water and the less effort you'll have to spend on paddling.

When packing your equipment into your canoe, follow these recommendations:

Don't bring anything you don't need. Remember that you can leave things like extra dry clothes, shoes, and towels in your vehicle.

Always pack gear in waterproof containers or dry bags. If you don't want it to get wet, put it in something waterproof.

Load your canoe in the water. This lets you see how the weight is distributed in the canoe, and help ensure that your canoe has proper trim (balance).

Keep the load low. The higher a boat's center of gravity, the more likely it is to capsize. In general, pack heavier gear at the bottom of your drybags and put lighter gear on top.

Secure your load if conditions allow (see sidebar). As long as you're paddling on flat waters, tie your gear bags into your canoe. That way, if you tip over, you won't have to go hunting for all your stuff.

Don't overload your canoe. All modern canoes have a maximum load rating; find out what it is, and make sure you don't go over it. Remember to include the weight of the people, too.

Put commonly used items in a thwart bag. If you're going to need access to something when you're on the water, a thwart bag is the best place for it.

Secure your bailers with line. Since you'll need them on the water, keep them unpacked but secured in the canoe.

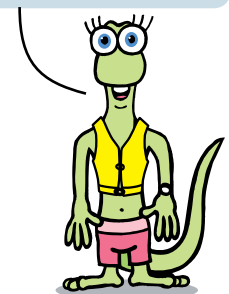


Use thwart bags to keep small gear and items dry and handy during your paddle.



About Securing Gear

Although you should always secure small items, like GPS units or bailers, there are some situations when tying your gear to your canoe can be a mistake. An overturned canoe will usually float bottom-up if the gear is tied in, and it can be very hard to right it, so consider the water conditions and the strength of the current when deciding whether to tie down your equipment. It is better to lose your gear than your life.





Paddling Gear

Packing Your Kayak

Because space is at a premium on most kayaks, you need to pack light, but don't leave behind essential safety gear just to cram a few more apples into your picnic bag. Most kayaks have four storage areas – the front hatch, the cockpit, the rear hatch, and the deck netting – although many touring kayaks have an additional day hatch offset behind the cockpit for easy access. Since they usually have rubber seals and secure straps, hatches provide dry storage space, while the cockpit and deck netting provide wet storage.

When packing your equipment into your kayak, follow these recommendations:

Don't bring anything you don't need. Remember that you can leave things like dry clothes, shoes, and towels in your vehicle.

Always pack gear in waterproof containers. Even the hatches on a kayak can get wet. Remember that small bags and boxes are easier to pack and arrange than large ones.

Load your kayak on land. Opening, closing, and securing hatches on the water can be a real problem.

Balance your load. Keep the weight evenly distributed, both from bow to stern and from starboard to port. Put smaller, heavier items in the front hatch and bulkier gear in the rear hatch. Check the balance by floating your kayak, but don't repack until you beach it!

Don't waste space. Both the front and rear hatches are wedge shaped, so put smaller items toward the points and leave the broader ends for bigger things.

Don't put anything in the cockpit you won't need while paddling. The more cluttered your cockpit, the less safe your kayak.

Put a water bottle and bailer in the cockpit. You'll need both on the water.

Only use the deck netting for a few smaller, lighter items. Too much weight on the deck makes a kayak unstable.

Secure your spare paddle on your kayak. Use special paddle clips or your deck rigging to secure it to your kayak deck.

Check your hatch covers. Make sure they're on straight and strapped down securely.



Use a deckbag to keep small gear and items dry and handy during your paddle. But before you throw your new digital camera or cell phone in it, some deckbags are fully waterproof, others are not. Make sure you know which one you are buying!





Paddling Gear

Essential Gear Checklist

Here's a checklist for you to copy and use. Every time you paddle, bring this essential equipment. Adjust this list for your trip duration and particular paddling and weather conditions. A good idea is to keep these items in a plastic storage bin. That way you won't have to spend time gathering it all for each trip.

Bring in the boat:

- ☐ PFD's (one for each paddler, should be worn at all times)
- ☐ Bailer (and sponge for kayakers)
- ☐ Water Pump for kayakers
- ☐ Paddle float for kayaking (and rescue sling, if desired)
- ☐ Spare paddle
- ☐ Throw rope or throw bag
- ☐ GPS and/or river map and compass
- ☐ Drybags (thick Ziplock bags will work in a pinch)
- ☐ First-aid kit
- ☐ Emergency kit
- ☐ Repair kit
- ☐ Knife (and folding saw if conditions call for one)
- ☐ Whistle (one attached to each PFD)
- ☐ Drinking water (enough for each paddler). A good rule of thumb is to bring a gallon of water per paddler per day for drinking while paddling. Bring extra water if paddling in extremely hot conditions and if doing any cooking on overnight trips.
- ☐ High-energy snack (protein bars, trail mix, etc.)
- ☐ A well balanced, hearty lunch. Paddling is exercise and you will work up a good appetite.
- ☐ Personal drybag or drybox (with your ID, car keys, etc.)
- ☐ Sunglasses (with strap). Considering buying a relatively inexpensive pair just for paddling that you won't mind losing.
- ☐ Wide brim hat
- ☐ Sunscreen
- ☐ Bug repellent
- ☐ Paddling shoes (and they won't do you any good unless you wear them!)
- ☐ Two-way radios: if paddling with a group, the lead boat and sweep (rear) boat should each carry two-way radios to stay in contact.

Leave in the car:

- ☐ Dry towels & clothes (including socks and underwear) and shoes
- ☐ Float Plan (see next page or visit PaddleDogNation.com to download a copy)

A few words about Personal Floatation Devices (PFD's)

Both the U.S. Coast Guard and the American Canoe Association recommend that ***all paddlers wear the proper PFD at all times while on the water.***

Children, PFD's & the law

Children should always wear a life jacket (PFD). Where state laws do not exist, ***federal law requires children under the age of 13 wear a life jacket when aboard a canoe or kayak.*** Set a good example for youngsters: wear your life jacket! (You can find links to state boating laws at PaddleDogNation.com) ***Children should only wear PFD's designed and approved for their size and weight.***

A special thanks to the American Canoe Association and the Professional Paddlesports Association for their help with information on PFD's.

Go to PaddleDogNation.com to find a downloadable version of this checklist that you can print out.





Planning

Estimating Paddling Speed

A comfortable paddling speed for beginners is about 2 to 2.5 mph on still water, while more experienced paddlers can average between 2 to 3.5 mph. Don't forget about the current! It can really mess with your time estimates.

Paddle Wear: avoid cotton.

Cotton retains moisture. It will actually wick warmth away from your body in cold conditions and keep you damp and uncomfortable in hot conditions. Wear synthetic clothing designed for outdoor activities and dress in layers when conditions call for it.

Specialized Paddle Wear

Any time the water temperature is less than 60° F, you need to wear specialized insulating clothing. Only experienced paddlers should venture out in cold conditions.

Planning Your Paddle

Planning is key to a safe paddle, especially when you're going for a long trip or through remote areas. **Before setting off, create a float plan** that details put-in and take-out locations, main and alternate routes, rest stops, paddling distances, estimated paddle times, and the like. It may take a little time and research, but a good float plan can keep you safe and on-course.

Here are a few things to keep in mind when making your float plan:

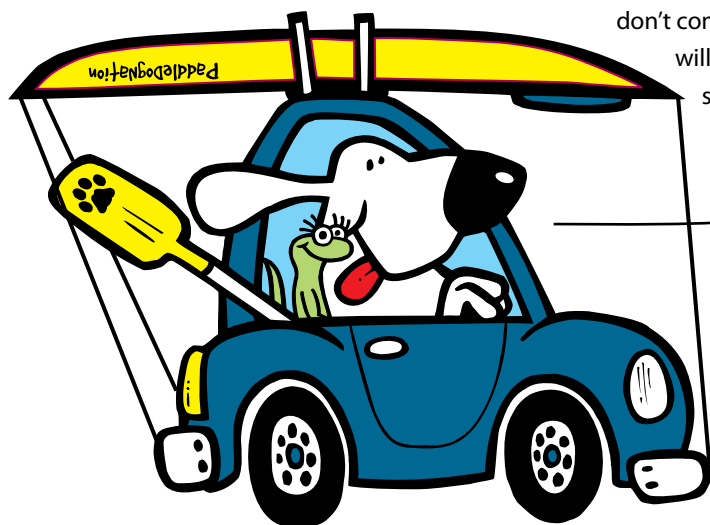
Put-in and take-out. Consider both distance and paddle time when picking put-in and take-out locations, and also terrain. Be sure to leave at least one car at the take-out spot or arrange for a shuttle of some kind, so you can get back to your vehicles at the put-in. Make sure you bring car keys with you in a secured drybox or drybag.

Routes, bail-outs, and rest stops. Always know what sort of waters you're going to paddle, and prepare accordingly. Be aware of any water hazards or rapids and how to deal with them (or avoid them), and locate a few potential bail-out points, just in case. Use a good river map to calculate distances, and pick rest stop locations every couple of hours. Plan some alternate routes, if possible; you never know when a tree might block your way. (You can often find good maps and river guidebooks at your local paddling store. They are always a good investment.)

Weather. Check the weather forecast before you paddle, and dress accordingly. If the weather is hot, remember to bring lots of drinking water, and if the weather is cold, bring a few chemical heating packs just in case. Mixing cold weather with cold water is a lot more dangerous than most people think!

Tell someone. File a copy of your **Float Plan** with someone reliable, and tell them who to contact (park rangers or county sheriffs are always a good bet) if you don't come back on time. That way, if you get in trouble, rescue teams will know where to start looking. Leave a second copy on the seat of your car.

Go to PaddleDogNation.com to find a **Float Plan** that you can download and print.





Planning

Planning Group Paddles

If you're planning a group paddle with many participants (as opposed to a paddle with just a few friends or family), here are a few things you need to consider in addition to your normal planning routine:

Pick a leader. The group leader is in charge of planning the paddle, making and filing the float plan, and notifying the group of any special equipment they need to bring. Always choose an experienced paddler as group leader.

Know everyone's limits. Find out how skilled, experienced, and in shape each paddler on your trip is, and plan a paddle that everyone in your group can complete safely. Are there any special health considerations? Is anyone allergic to insect bites, if so make sure they carry proper medication.

Share the plan. Send everyone in your group a copy of the float plan as soon as possible.

Transporting. Make sure that you have enough room in the vehicles at the take-out spot for everyone on the paddle, and make sure everyone leaves their towels and dry clothes there, too.

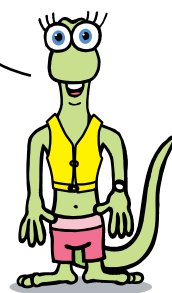
Group briefing. Before launching your boats, the group leader should go over the float plan briefly with everyone at the put-in, and remind the group of any water hazards on the trip. You should also do a group equipment check, and make sure everyone is ready for the weather and water conditions.

Stay together. For safety, groups should stay together from put-in to take-out. It's impossible to avoid spreading out somewhat during a paddle, so assign two of the more experienced paddlers as lead and sweep boats. The lead boat and sweep boat should carry two-way radios to stay in contact.

Help out. Everyone in your group must be ready to help anyone who needs it as best they can. Some of the more experienced paddlers (and probably the team leader, too) should stay close to the less-experienced members of the group.

Avoid other boats. Keep your group as far away from other boats as possible; the more boats in the mix, the more likely a collision.

The bigger the group, the easier they can lose track of you. Stick close to your paddle group!





Planning

Pre-Paddle Tips

These are some things that all paddlers need to think about *before* they get on the water:

Capsizing. It doesn't matter how good you are, every paddler flips over eventually. Adding grab handles or perimeter lines to your boat can make it easier to get back in. And always wear your PFD! Know and practise both self and assisted rescues.

Weather changes. No forecast is ever 100% accurate, and sometimes the weather can change in minutes. Keep an eye on the sky, and be ready for temperatures 20° F higher or lower than predicted.

Repairs. Boats get holes, so you need to know how to repair them. Always check your boat, your paddles, and your gear for damage before you launch.

Use your checklist. Use the pre-launch checklist on the next page and go over it each time you paddle. Customize it for your particular location and paddling preferences.

Stow your gear. Loose lines and gear can be deadly on the water, especially in an emergency. Make sure everything you're not using is secured in place at all times, and always stow things properly after you're done with them.

Lines and knots. Ropes and lines are incredibly useful on the water, so bring a throw line when you paddle. Ropes and lines are a lot *less* useful if you don't know how to tie a secure knot, so learn to tie at least one good maritime knot as soon as you can.

Know about the local wildlife. Study up on the biting and stinging insects. Are there venomous snakes to be aware of? In the southeast you may encounter alligators and if paddling offshore you may encounter sharks. The more you know about wildlife, the better you'll be able to handle encounters with them. (Do any of your paddling partners have allergies to insect stings? If so, do they have special medication? Find out *before* you head out!)

Stimulant and Intoxicants. Save alcohol, tobacco, caffeine and other stimulants or intoxicants for after your paddle. All of them affect your metabolism in ways that can impair your judgement or health while paddling. Both alcohol and caffeine dehydrate your body. Alcohol and hypothermia can be a deadly combination.

A Few Simple Facts:

In 2004 the U.S. Coast Guard reported that of those who drowned, 90% were not wearing PFD's and that alcohol was involved in about a third of all reported boating fatalities. Wear your PFD. Save alcohol for after your paddle.

Weather Alert Radios

If you're going to be doing a fair amount of paddling, it's a good idea to invest in a Weather Alert radio. These special radios are tuned in to all NOAA alert stations, and can operate on stand-by mode with audio warning for special weather alerts.





Planning

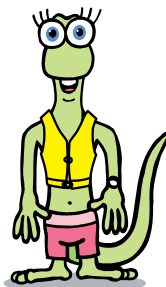
Pre-Launch Checklist

Before launching your boat, make sure that:

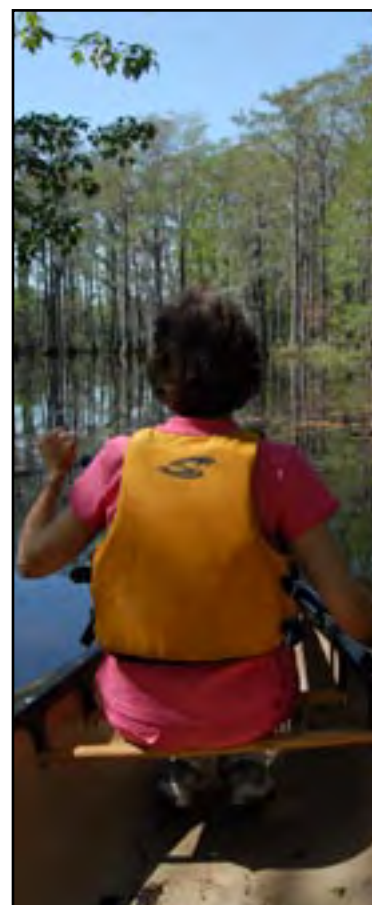
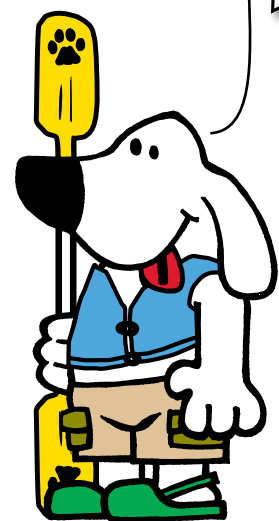
- ☐ You filed your float plan with someone reliable
- ☐ You have a vehicle waiting at the take-out point with dry towels, clothes, and shoes
- ☐ You have checked the weather forecast for the day
- ☐ You are wearing appropriate clothing for the weather and water conditions
- ☐ You have checked your boat, paddle, and PFD (and sprayskirt/spraycover) for damage and wear
- ☐ You have all the equipment on your gear checklist
- ☐ All your equipment is well packed and secured
- ☐ Your hatches are secure (kayak)
- ☐ All your lines (ropes) are attached and secured
- ☐ Your spare paddle is secured to the boat
- ☐ You have your keys and ID in a drybag or drybox secured to your boat
- ☐ Your bailer is secured and easily accessible
- ☐ Your drinking water and high-energy snacks are secured and easily accessible
- ☐ Your self-rescue gear is secured and easily accessible
- ☐ Your throw bag or throw line is secured and easily accessible
- ☐ Your knife is secured, easily accessible, and either sheathed or closed
- ☐ You have a river map along with a compass or a GPS secured and accessible
- ☐ You put on your sunscreen (don't forget to reapply it as directed).
- ☐ You put on your bug spray (don't forget to reapply it as directed).
- ☐ Your sunscreen and bug spray are secured to your boat and easily accessible
- ☐ Your PFD is fitted snugly and comfortably
- ☐ Your whistle is attached to your PFD
- ☐ Your sunglasses are secured to your neck with the strap
- ☐ Your hat (or helmet) is on your head
- ☐ After packing all of your gear, your boat is well-balanced (trim)
- ☐ If going on open water, have at least one VHF radio for the group.

Sally says...

Most sunscreens can wear off after about an hour if you are swimming or sweating, even the waterproof ones. And always put on bug spray after you put on sunscreen, or the bug spray won't work!



Go to PaddleDogNation.com to find a **Pre-Launch Checklist** that you can download and print.





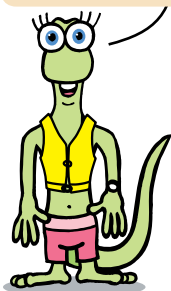
Paddling

Get training!

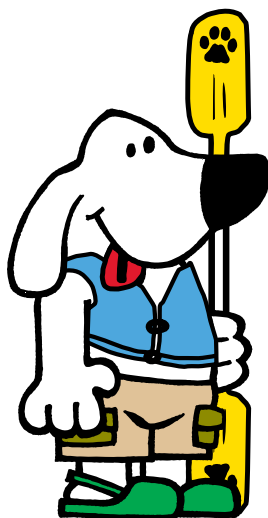
Often you will have to launch your canoe in less than ideal conditions (into waves, from rocky shorelines or a dock). You should take a paddling class from a certified trainer to learn the safest ways to enter and launch your canoe under a variety of conditions.



To ensure better stability, the stern paddler should always get in the canoe first and get out last. If you are paddling alone in a tandem canoe, sit as close to the middle of the boat as you can, and balance your load so the bow is slightly higher than the stern.



When entering, exiting, or turning around in your canoe, maintaining a minimum of 3 points of contact at all times.



Getting Into Your Canoe

Before you can paddle, you have to get your boat on the water and yourself in the boat. Below is a common method for entering your canoe on calm water from a smooth beach. Here's how to do it.

After your canoe is on the water, fully loaded and properly balanced:

- 1) Turn your canoe so that it's parallel to the shore,
- 2) Make sure that you're facing the same direction as the canoe's bow,
- 3) Have your paddle partner hold the boat steady at the bow,
- 4) Brace your paddle shaft (**not** the blade) across the gunwales of the canoe a little ways in front of your seat,
- 5) Step into the canoe with your inner foot (the one closest to the canoe) and put your foot down in the **center** of the boat between the paddle shaft and the seat,
- 6) Keeping your hips as low as possible and using your paddle shaft to steady yourself, bring your other foot into the canoe and immediately sink down onto your knees (preferably on your kneeling pad), and
- 7) Spread your knees wide, then bring your hips up to the front edge of the seat and sit down.

Your paddle partner should use the same sequence to get in the bow of the canoe (except for step 3, of course). Once everyone is in the boat, **carefully** shift people and gear around to adjust the final balance of your canoe.



Bracing with your paddle shaft, bring your inner foot into the center of the canoe.



Steady yourself with the paddle shaft, keep your hips low and bring your other foot in.



Immediately sink to your knees, then bring your hips up and back on the seat.





Paddling

Getting Into Your Kayak

Although sit-in kayaks and sit-on kayaks are different in many ways, the process of getting into them is essentially the same. Below is a common method for entering your kayak on calm water from a smooth beach.

After your kayak is fully loaded and all the hatches are secured, but before you get it in the water:

- 1) Make sure your kayak is on flat ground,
- 2) Get into the cockpit and adjust the seat and the foot pegs to a comfortable position. Exit the kayak, and...
- 3) Put your kayak in the water, load it, and make sure that it's properly balanced, then turn it so that it's parallel to the shore,
- 4) Brace your paddle shaft *right behind* (see picture insert) the cockpit trim (it's called 'coaming') so that one blade extends out to the shore and is resting on firm ground.
- 5) While facing the bow of the kayak, squat down and hold on to both the cockpit trim and the paddle shaft with one hand, then grab the paddle farther down its shaft with your other hand.
- 6) Support your weight as evenly as possible with both hands, then step up with your inner foot (the one closest to the canoe) and slide it into the cockpit,
- 7) Carefully slide your rear sideways over the edge of the cockpit until it's hovering just over the seat, all the while supporting your weight with both hands, then pull your other leg into the cockpit and line it up beside the first, and
- 8) Drop down into the cockpit until you are sitting down with your feet braced against the foot pegs.

Once you're in the cockpit, adjust your position until you're comfortable and then attach your sprayskirt (if you're using one). Once your sprayskirt is secure, carefully shift yourself and your gear as needed to adjust the final balance of your kayak. To get out of your kayak, just reverse the process.



Brace your paddle right behind the cockpit trim (the coaming).



Use the paddle shaft to maintain your balance, NOT to support all your weight. Too much pressure can cause the shaft to snap.



As you swing your left leg into the cockpit, use your right hand to support most of your weight.

Get training!

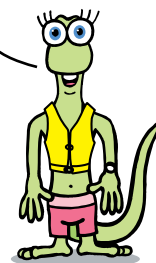
Often you will have to launch your kayak in less than ideal conditions (into waves, from rocky shorelines or a dock). You should take a paddling class from a certified trainer to learn the safest ways to enter and launch your canoe under a variety of conditions.



Never brace your paddle shaft on the coaming when you are getting into a kayak. Brace it just behind and against the coaming.

Even though your paddle will act as a brace, **don't put too much pressure or weight on it!** Try to move your kayak as little as possible while getting in.

If you're paddling a sit-on kayak and you're tall enough to pull it through your straddled legs without getting stuck, float your 'yak in shallow water and pull it forward between your legs until you can sit down on the seat. It's a lot faster and easier that way!





Paddling

Keeping Your Boat Stable

The lower and closer to the center line all the weight in your boat is, the more stable your boat will be. Any weight carried above the gunwales is unstable, and as that weight moves off the centerline, your boat will roll to compensate; if that weight moves far enough off-center, your boat will capsize.

You and your gear are the primary sources of weight in your boat, so load your gear carefully and keep these tips in mind when paddling:

Always stay within your boat's weight capacity. An overloaded boat can be unpredictably unstable.

Always keep three points of contact when moving in a boat.

Either both of your hands and a foot or both of your feet and a hand should always be touching the boat. If you're moving forward or backward inside a canoe, keep your hands on the gunwales, stay as close to the centerline as possible, keep your weight as close to the bottom as possible.

Always keep your shoulders inside the gunwales of the boat.

If you have to reach for something, either use your paddle or get in close enough to reach it without leaning over the side.

Always sit up straight. And keep your shoulders basically parallel to the water, too.

Always communicate. Tell your paddling partner what you're going to do **before** you start moving around the boat.

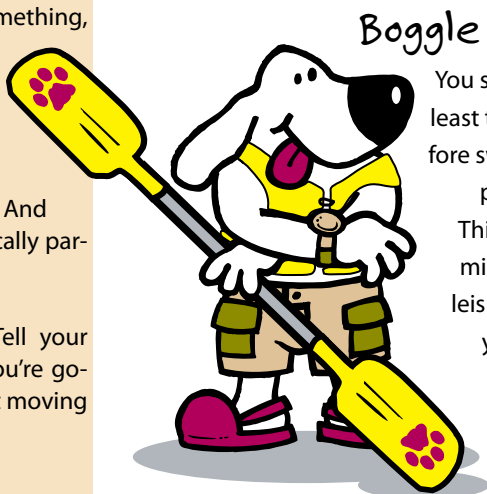
Paddling Your Canoe

You and your partner should paddle each stroke at the same time, on opposite sides of the canoe. The paddler in the bow of the boat chooses a side and sets the pace, while the paddler in the stern follows the pace and steers the canoe. The bow paddler should switch sides in a regular pattern to reduce fatigue, and should paddle slowly enough to give the stern paddler a little extra time to steer.

There are many different strokes for paddling canoes – too many to list here – but this is a good, basic stroke to start out with. First, find your proper grip by holding the paddle out in front of you at arm's length, then grabbing the top grip of the paddle with one hand and moving your other hand down the shaft of the paddle until your hands are shoulder width apart. Be sure to keep your shaft hand loose enough that the shaft can rotate! Once you've got the right grip:

- 1) Keeping your back straight, your paddle shaft vertical, and your paddle blade perpendicular to the direction of your stroke, turn your shaft-hand shoulder forward by twisting at the waist and put your paddle blade into the water about a foot in front of your knee,
- 2) Keep your back straight and your arms stiff (but don't lock your elbows), and uncoil your torso and shoulders to bring your paddle blade even with your knee,
- 3) Still keeping your back straight, your paddle shaft vertical, and your paddle blade perpendicular to the direction of your stroke, pull your paddle blade out of the water, and..
- 4) Repeat.

Paddling Tip: When you change sides while paddling, you also change your grip by swapping hands. To make switching sides easier, try marking the place for your shaft hand with some tape or a pen until your body gets used to this grip.

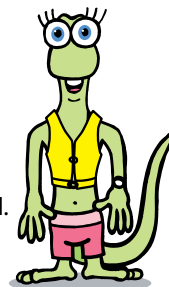


Boggle says...

You should make at least ten strokes before switching sides, probably more. Thirty strokes per minute is a good, leisurely pace, but your canoe will become easier to steer the faster you paddle.

Sally says...

If your paddle shaft is not vertical during your stroke, or if you keep your paddle blade in the water past the center line of your body, you will probably send your canoe off course. Short, straight strokes provide both power and control.





Paddling

Paddling Your Kayak

To paddle your kayak in a straight line, use smooth, even strokes on alternating sides of your boat, keeping both the paddle blade (the one that's in the water) and the path of your stroke parallel to your kayak. You can easily steer your kayak by paddling more on the side you wish to turn than on the other, by paddling backwards on the side you wish to turn, or by using one of your paddle blades as a rudder. Often, kayak paddle blades are slightly spoon or dihedral shaped to catch the water better and provide a stronger stroke, and some blades are lopsided (asymmetrical) for better hydrodynamics; when using a paddle with lopsided blades always keep the long edge on top.

As with canoes, there are a number of different strokes for paddling your kayak; this is a good stroke to begin with. To find your proper grip, put the center of your paddle shaft on top of your head and move your hands until both arms make right angles at the elbow, then bring your paddle down and grip the shaft with your thumbs and forefingers (like the 'okay' sign), leaving the other fingers loose. Once you've got the right grip:

- 1) Keeping your back straight and your paddle blade perpendicular to the direction of your stroke, turn your shoulder (whichever one is on the same side as the stroke you're about to do) forward by twisting at the waist and put your paddle blade into the water as far forward as you can reach comfortably,
- 2) Keep your back straight and your arms stiff (but don't lock your elbows), and uncoil your torso and shoulders to bring your paddle blade even with your body,
- 3) Still keeping your back straight and your paddle blade perpendicular to the direction of your stroke, pull your paddle blade out of the water, and
- 4) Repeat on the opposite side of your kayak using the opposite blade of your paddle.

Paddling Tip: For an easier pace, you should keep the angle of your paddle shaft between 45 degrees and 60 degrees when the blade is in the water; for a stronger stroke, bring your paddle blade closer to your kayak and keep the angle of the shaft closer to vertical.

Paddling Tip: Your shoulders and back are a lot stronger than your arms, so use them!



NOTE: Although this section is written for beginning paddlers, it cannot take the place of a class taught by a certified instructor, nor is it meant to. This section is designed to refresh your memory and provide information additional to the basic paddling course that you've already taken. **Do NOT go on the water until you've taken a certified canoe or kayak course!**



General Paddling Tips

The following tips apply to both canoeists and kayakers:

Keep your back straight and your hips loose. A straight back helps keep your boat stable, and loose hips let your boat rock and move under you.

Use your shoulders, stomach, and back to paddle, not your arms. Torso muscles are stronger than your arm muscles, and they'll keep working longer.

Keep your hands in front of your shoulders when paddling. You can injure your shoulders badly if you put too much pressure on them at the wrong angle, and as long as your hands stay in front of the line your shoulders make, that probably won't happen. If you need to put your paddle in the water behind you, twist your body to turn your shoulders, and keep your hands in front of them.

Keep your paddle blade perpendicular to the direction of your stroke. This ensures that you get the most motion out of your paddling efforts.



Paddling Safety



Download “[Rules of the Road](#)” from the American Canoe Association for more information about navigation guidelines and safety.

NOTE: The rules, signals, and laws mentioned here represent a very brief overview of the rules, signals, and laws that apply to paddlers in the United States at the time of publication. For a complete list of current rules, signals, and laws, go to the U.S. Coast Guard’s Navigation Center website at: www.navcen.uscg.gov/mwv/navrules/navrules.htm. **For links to all state boating laws visit the Learning Center at PaddleDogNation.com.**

Universal Signals

“Help!” Wave your paddle over your head in a circular motion, or give three long blows on your whistle.

“Are You Okay?” Tap the top of your head with your hand and then point to the paddler you’re addressing. If they tap their head three times, they’re fine; if not, they need help.

“Stop!” Hold your paddle horizontally over your head.

“Go This Way!” Use your paddle to point the way.

“All Clear!” Hold your paddle up vertically and keep it still.

Rules of the Water

Whenever you’re paddling, you are subject to a number of rules and laws that dictate what you can and can’t do, and how you should interact with other boats. Each state has its own set of rules (so make sure you know the local laws before you paddle), but all of them build on the Federal regulations. Here are a few rules to keep in mind while you’re on the water:

Navigation Rules

The Navigation Rules are a code of conduct rather than a declaration of rights, which means that their sole purpose is to **prevent collisions**, not establish right-of-way for particular vessels. As a paddler, you should remember that you are very mobile and agile. Larger vessels are not and the depth of the channel can limit deep draft vessels. Make use of your smaller size and agility to move out of the way.

The Navigational Rules state that:

- Boats less than 20 meters must not impede the passage of larger vessels, whether under power or not.
- Boats traveling against the current must give way to boats traveling with the current.
- A vessel that overtakes and passes another vessel must steer clear of that other vessel, and the vessel being passed must maintain course as much as possible.
- When meeting head-on, boats should steer to their right (starboard) so that each boat will pass the other on its left (port) side.
- When crossing paths, any vessel that has another vessel on its right (starboard) side must give way to that vessel and alter course so that it does not cross in front of that vessel.

Rules Specific to Paddlers:

- Paddlers should stay as far to the right of any commercial waterway as possible.
- Paddlers should avoid crossing traffic lanes if at all possible.

Rules for Paddling at Night:

- Any boat operating in U.S. waters between sunset and sunrise, even canoes and kayaks, are required by law to show lights from sunset to sunrise. At a minimum, paddlers must carry a white flashlight that they can shine towards an approaching vessel in time to prevent a collision, which means that you must have it at hand, not stowed in a drybag or hatch.
- Any boat operating in U.S. waters between sunset and sunrise, even canoes and kayaks, are required by law to carry a distress signal.

Paddlers do not travel as fast as motorized craft. If you see a powerboat, do not assume that you can pass ahead of it if traveling across its path. The safest way for paddle craft to cross the path of a powerboat is astern. Remember to cross other boats as a group instead of straggling across the river and blocking other traffic.

Don’t let your safety depend on others finding YOU on the water.

From Rules of the Road by the American Canoe Association. Used by permission.



Paddling Safety

Water Safety Tips

Before you can think about a rescue, someone has to be in the water. If you're the one in the drink, here are a few tips to keep in mind:

- **Don't panic.** Even if you're stuck upside-down in a kayak, take a moment to calm yourself before you do anything, if at all possible.
- **Stay with your boat.** Most canoes and kayaks will float when capsized, as long as they're not over their weight limit. Since your boat is also your ticket home, don't lose it.
- **Always stay upstream of your boat.** If you get caught between your boat and a rock, you can die, and the stronger the current, the more likely you will.
- **Keep hold of your paddle.** If you can't paddle your boat, that ticket home becomes a ticket to nowhere. Never assume that your spare paddle is still attached to your boat unless you have no choice.
- **Keep your feet at the surface and pointing downstream.** That way, you can see what's coming, and push off if you have to. Your PFD will keep you floating, so you can concentrate on getting back in your boat.

Freeing a Grounded Boat

If your canoe or kayak gets stuck on a rock or other water hazard, and you can't get it free by paddling, here are a few tips that can help get you on your way again:

- **Act quickly.** The longer you're stuck, the more likely you are to damage your boat.
- **Lean downstream into the obstruction.** By leaning downstream, you're letting the current hit more of the underside of your hull; this gets the current working with you to free your boat, and it also helps keep the current from pulling your boat down under the water. Just don't lean so far that you're in danger of capsizing.
- **Brace your boat until it stops moving.** If leaning downstream doesn't free your boat, brace against whatever's handy to stop your boat's movement before you try anything else.
- **Push against the obstacle.** Push against the obstacle with your hands or paddle to try and lift, twist, or pry your boat free. Canoe paddles are usually sturdier than kayak paddles, but either way, be careful not to break your paddle.
- **Bounce.** If you can't push it free, try bouncing up and down to briefly take your weight off the boat. If this doesn't work fairly quickly, stop bouncing or you might damage your boat.
- **Get out and push.** If the current isn't very strong and the water's not too deep, you can use a little brute force to fix the problem. If there's a significant current or if the water's deeper than your chest, **do not** try to push your boat free.
- **Get help.** If your boat is stuck on a hazard in the middle of a strong current in deep water and nothing else works, get help from another boat.
- **Bail out.** If you're all alone and your boat is stuck and you have absolutely no

Get Training!

Although this section is written for beginning paddlers, it cannot take the place of a class taught by a certified instructor, nor is it meant to. This section is designed to refresh your memory and provide information additional to the basic paddling course that you've already taken. **Do NOT use any of these techniques until you've practiced them under the supervision of a certified canoe or kayak instructor!**



If there are two paddlers in the boat, the one who is farther downstream should lean and brace the boat while the other paddler works to free it.





Paddling Safety

Get Training!

Although this section is written for beginning paddlers, it cannot take the place of a class taught by a certified instructor, nor is it meant to. This section is designed to refresh your memory and provide information additional to the basic paddling course that you've already taken. **Do NOT use any of these techniques until you've practiced them under the supervision of a certified canoe or kayak instructor!**



Canoe Self-Rescue

If you capsize in a canoe, the simplest and most effective solution is to pull your canoe ashore, dump out the water, repack the load, and then get back in. Even if your paddle partner stays in the boat when you go over the side, you should still re-enter from the shore.

Kayak Rescue Skills

Kayak rescue skills are the most basic, fundamental skills that all kayakers must learn. You must take a beginning kayaking course and learn the techniques involved from a certified instructor, in a controlled environment, and then you must practice -a lot! Consider taking more advanced courses to sharpen your skills. Schedule a few practice sessions with your paddling buddies at the beginning of each paddling season. Being proficient in kayak rescue skills can save your life, or the life of a fellow paddler.

In this section we'll take a brief look at the various types of rescues, the maneuvers and skills required, and some of the rescue gear involved.

What is a rescue?

A kayak rescue is simply the set of techniques or maneuvers a paddler uses to re-enter or "roll" a kayak after it has capsized (see the sidebar for more on rolls). It also refers to assisting another paddler who has capsized. It is called a "self rescue" when the paddler performs the techniques solo, and an "assisted rescue" when a fellow paddler helps the capsized paddler. We'll keep our discussion focused on rescues that involve exiting a capsized kayak and re-entering it; rolls are advanced techniques.

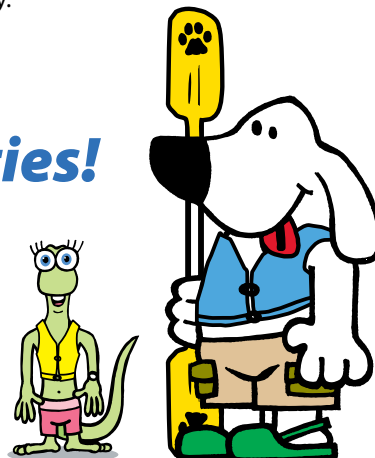
Both the self rescue and assisted rescue consist of four maneuvers: the Wet Exit, Righting the Kayak, Re-entry, and Recovery.

A brief note about Rolls

There are several kinds of rolls. The most commonly known is perhaps the "Eskimo Roll," in which the paddler is able to capsize and right her kayak without exiting the cockpit. Another type of roll is "Re-entry and Roll," in which the paddler wet exits her boat, installs her paddlefloat on her paddle, re-enters the capsized kayak and uses the paddle/paddlefloat to assist in righting the boat. Rolls are advanced techniques and require certified instruction with lots of practice!

Know Your Rescue Priorities!

1. People
2. Boats
3. Gear





Paddling Safety

Kayak Rescue Skills (continued)

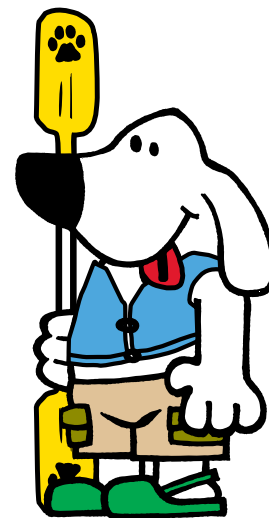
The Wet Exit

A wet exit is the technique of exiting a capsized kayak. For sit-on-top kayakers, it's a simple affair; once you go over, you're out of the boat! For kayakers in decked boats, it's a bit more complicated. The main thing to remember is to remain calm. Most novice paddlers are apprehensive about the thought of being upside down in a kayak with or without wearing a sprayskirt. But exiting is actually a very simple process that will only take a few seconds. And your PFD will actually pull you to the surface once you exit the kayak cockpit.

The steps to complete a wet exit include: (This does not replace instruction from qualified instructors.)

1. Tuck forward to protect your face and chest
2. Release the spray skirt (if wearing one).
3. With your hands on the coming beside each hip, push your bum out of the kayak, completing a somersault motion with your body.
4. At this point you should be free of the kayak and as mentioned before, your PFD will bring you to the surface of the water. Don't forget to hold on to your boat and paddle!

Don't panic! As long as you can hold your breath for 10 seconds, you can count to two and still get out of the cockpit safely!



Righting the Kayak

Righting a kayak is the technique of turning a capsized kayak right side up. The actual techniques vary according to the type of boat (sit-on-top or sit-in), whether it is a self or assisted rescue, and general conditions (waves, current and wind). During an assisted rescue it is very important for the rescuer to take command and communicate with the kayaker in the water.

Re-entry

There are a number of ways for a paddler to re-enter a kayak. A solo kayaker can use a paddlefloat, as well as a rescue sling (see side bars) to help assist herself back into the kayak.

The paddlefloat is an inflatable cushion or piece of foam that attaches to the paddle blade so that your paddle can act as a temporary outrigger. Then your paddle can provide stability for the kayak and a platform to assist your re-entry. The rescue sling is a piece of rope or webbing that acts as a step to help you re-enter.

In an assisted rescue, the rescuer uses his boat and body to provide stability for the swimmers boat. The swimmer then can use a scissor kick to propel her body up on to the deck of her kayak or she can use a rescue sling.

Rescue Slings (aka Rescue Stirrups)

A rescue sling is a length of rope or webbing that acts as a step to assist you in a re-entry. They are especially useful for paddlers that are fatigued or lack upper body strength. Slings are relatively inexpensive and usually have a clip so you can attach them to your deck line or PFD.

Paddlefloats

Paddlefloats come in both inflatable and foam models. Each have their benefits and weaknesses. Inflatables are less bulky, but require time to inflate them. Foam models are more bulky, but are quicker to install on your paddle. Talk to a good salesman at a paddlesports store about which model will be best for you. Bring your paddle to the store to make sure the paddlefloat fits on your paddle blade securely. Once on the water, secure your paddlefloat to the deck of your kayak so it is readily accessible if you capsize.



Paddling Safety

Throw a Kayak Rescue Party!

Once you have learned rescue techniques from a certified trainer, you will need practice to become proficient in them. Why not throw a Kayak Rescue Party?

- At the beginning of every paddling season, invite some paddling buddies to practice their rescue techniques with you.
- You can hold it in a swimming pool or a park with some calm water.
- Make a day of it! Enjoy a picnic and plan some paddling trips for the year.
- Make it an annual event to kick off the paddling season.

Kayak Rescue Skills (continued)

Recovery

Once back in the cockpit of her boat, the kayaker will need to secure her paddle, use her hand pump to remove the excess water from the cockpit, secure her equipment (hand pump, rescues sling, etc.), take a moment to compose herself and evaluate her ability to continue paddling.

Putting it all together...

Always wear your PFD and always paddle with a buddy!

As you have just read, kayak rescues involve multiple maneuvers and techniques. The novice paddler should never be in the position that she has to perform a self rescue (unless in class). The conditions that caused the novice to capsize (rough waves, current, wind, etc.) will make a self rescue difficult and may cause a second capsize. The novice should learn how to perform both rescues, but should always paddle with a buddy and always wear a PFD!

Typical Safety & Rescue Gear



Infant and Child Sized PFD's



Adult PFD



Foam Paddle Float (top)
Inflatable Paddle Float (bottom)



Safety kit with paddle float,
hand pump, paddle leash, etc.



Emergency Medical Kit
in Dry Bag



Rescue Sling (stirrup)



Paddle Leash



Hand pump
Rescue whistle



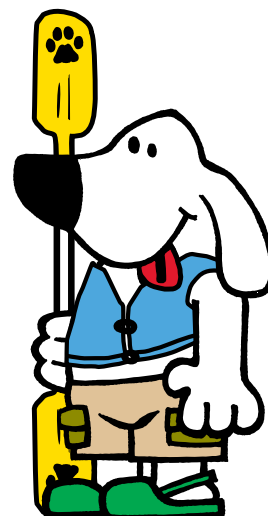
Care & Maintenance

Maintaining Your Canoe

Keeping your canoe in good shape is an essential part of paddling safely, and a well-maintained canoe can last longer than you will. To keep your canoe safe and sound, follow these tips each time you get home from paddling:

- **Never drag or drop it.** When you're hauling your canoe off of your truck or trailer, try not to drop it and definitely don't drag it. Get some help, if you need to; it's a lot cheaper than buying a new boat. Dragging your canoe will shorten the lifespan of your boat significantly. Never, ever drag your boat!
- **Drain it and clean it.** After you've unloaded all of your gear, tip your canoe over to drain out the water and hose it down to get rid of sand, dirt, leaves, and the occasional Gatorade spill. After draining it, leave your canoe upright for a few hours to let it dry. *If you've been out in salt water, rinse the entire canoe thoroughly. Don't forget to rinse your PFD and other gear as well!*
- **Check it for damage.** Always inspect your canoe before you store it, and make any necessary repairs as soon as possible. Touch up any exposed wood using varnish or oil, especially where you see scratches.
- **Store it inside or under cover.** Weather can cause an amazing amount of damage to a canoe, regardless of its construction. If you must store it outdoors, invest in a tarp or a specially made canoe cover to protect your boat.
- **When stored outdoors store it upside-down.** Support your canoe using padded ropes, saw-horses, or specially made racks, and make sure that the supports rest about a third of the way in from each end of the canoe. Do not store your canoe on the ground, as that can damage the gunwales.
- **Protective Coatings.** Spray-on protective coatings (like 303-UV) will help protect your boat from sunlight and oxidation. Apply at the beginning and end of the paddling season.

If you live in snow country, don't forget to brush the snow off every couple of days during the winter.



Boat Storage



Talic BundlePack



Talic SlingSet



Talic SeaHorse

There is a wide variety of commercial canoe and kayak storage products available. They are usually reasonable priced and worth the investment.

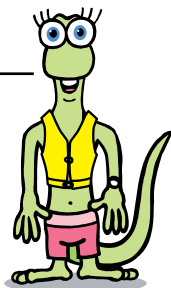


Care & Maintenance

Rudder & Skeg Maintenance

If your kayak has a rudder or skeg, be sure to check the complete system at the beginning and end of your paddling season. Inspect the control lines to make sure they are running free and in good condition. Check to see if the rudder moves freely on the axis. Clean away any sand or grime and tighten all bolts and screws.

The best way to check the hull for damage is to put your kayak in a dark room and shine a flashlight inside the cockpit and each of the hatches. If you see any light, you will need to fix the hole.



Protective Coatings

Spray-on protective coatings (like 303-UV or Boat Guard) will help protect your boat from sunlight and oxidation. Apply at the beginning and end of the paddling season.

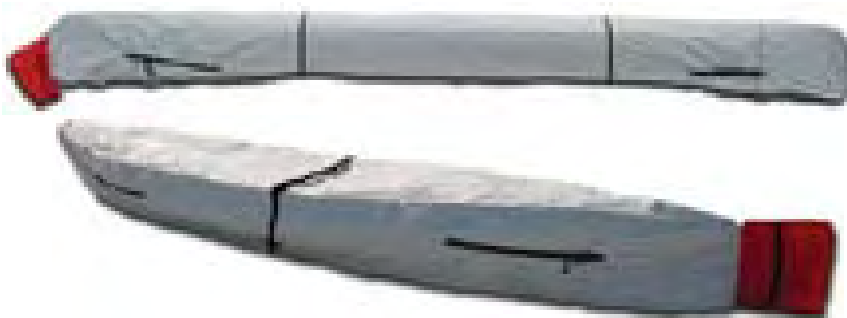


Maintaining Your Kayak

Without proper care and storage, a good kayak can go bad very, very quickly. To keep your kayak in tip-top shape, do these things after every paddle:

- **Never drag or drop it.** Bumps and scrapes can ruin the hull, so get a friend to help move your kayak or buy a cart.
- **Clean and rinse it out.** Once it's unloaded, dump out all the water from the cockpit and use a hose to spray down every exposed surface. Check the hatches to make sure they're both clean and dry, and let your kayak air-dry before storing it. *If you've been out in salt water, rinse the entire kayak and all the rigging thoroughly. Don't forget to rinse your PFD and other gear as well!*
- **Check all components.** Your kayak has a lot more components than a canoe. At least annually check the deck rigging, foot pegs, bulkheads, and toggles. Replace frayed cords and tighten all bolts and nuts.
- **Check for damage.** Always check the hull for scratches and holes before putting it in storage, and fix these problems as soon as you find them.
- **Store it inside or under cover.** A cool garage is best, but any shelter is better than none. If you must store it outdoors, use a tarp to protect your boat.
- **Keep it off the ground.** Don't leave your kayak resting on the floor. There are many different ways to hang or support your kayak, and it doesn't necessarily need to be upside-down. Just make sure the supports don't put pressure on the weak parts of the boat.
- **Cover the cockpit and hatches.** Lots of different critters would love to make their homes in places like this. You can get a cockpit cover if you like (basically a spray-skirt without a hole), or you can make one. Just be sure your cockpit and hatches are bone dry before you seal them.
- **Protective Coatings.** Spray-on protective coatings (like 303-UV) will help protect your boat from sunlight and oxidation. Apply at the beginning and end of the paddling season.

Boat Covers



You can purchase commercial canoe and kayak covers. These from Danuu are easy to put on and take off, protect your boat from UV radiation, and include an attached red storage bag that doubles as a visibility flag while you're on the road.



Additional Resources



American Canoe Association

www.americancanoe.org

A great place for all levels of paddlers. Check their Safety section for a variety of free downloadable safety guides and brochures.

"The American Canoe Association (ACA) is a nationwide, not for profit organization that is in service to the broader paddling public by providing education on matters related to paddling, supporting stewardship of the paddling environment, and enabling programs and events to support paddlesport recreation."



Paddlesports Industry Association

www.paddlesportsindustry.org

A paddlesports industry group that has an online directory of retailers and outfitters, searchable by country, state and metro area.

"The Paddlesports Industry Association is the premier trade association promoting paddlesports. PPA members help outdoor enthusiasts experience the fun and joy of rafting, kayaking, and canoeing the lakes, rivers, white-water, streams, creeks, bays and coastal waters in the United States and internationally."



Paddle Canada

www.paddlingcanada.com

"PADDLE CANADA (formerly the Canadian Recreational Canoeing Association) was conceived in 1971 as a result of the perceived need that recreational paddling enthusiasts from across Canada required a national body to co-ordinate the efforts of those involved in non-competitive canoeing and kayaking. Today, the Association acts as the national office for ten provincial and three territorial associations, as well as 2.3 million recreational paddlers."



U.S. Coast Guard Boating Safety

www.uscgboating.org

Good general safety information for recreational boaters. Very good section on PFD's.



TakeMeFishing.org

If you like kayak and canoe fishing or want to give it a try, visit this site. It has a lot of good information and resources on everything you need to know. It also has good tips on getting kids started.



PaddleDogNation.com

Visit our site for directories to local paddling clubs and businesses, articles and how-to's, instructional videos, links, discussion boards, checklists, mini-posters, event calendars, and much more. Free membership.



North America Safe Boating Campaign

The North American Safe Boating Campaign aims at spreading a message of boating safety, encourages boater education, and helps to save lives. The campaign produces a variety of safe boating information intended to enhance and supplement the individual campaigns that take place through groups, associations and organizations across the United States and Canada

American Canoe Association



Dedicated to helping people enjoy the outdoors using canoes, kayaks and rafts since 1880.

Mission Statement

ACA (est. 1880) is a nation wide, not for profit organization serving the broader paddling public by providing education related to all aspects of paddling, stewardship support to help protect paddling environments, and sanctioning of programs and events that promote paddlesport recreation.

Join the ACA Today

Individual: \$40 Student rate: \$25 Families: \$60

Annual Benefits Include:

- Six issues of *Paddler* magazine
 - Monthly editions of *ACA eNews* electronic newsletter
 - Member only discounts on the new Subaru vehicle of your choice
 - Access to hundreds of ACA sanctioned paddling events including trips, races and clinics
 - Discounts on books, videos and other merchandise from the ACA eStore
 - Communications and alerts on paddling issues
- IMPORTANT to You!**



ACA

We Are People Who Paddle

Any Boat, Any Water

www.americancanoe.org



American Canoe Association
7432 Alban Station Blvd., Suite B-232
Springfield, VA 22150
Phone: 1.800.929.5162



MAIL TO: 7432 Alban Station Blvd. Suite B-232 • Springfield, VA 22150 • 1-800-929-5162 aca@americancanoe.org

Join the ACA!

Name: _____

Address: _____

City: _____ State: _____ Zip: _____

Phone: _____

Email: _____

Send me *ACA eNews* ____ Don't share my address with commercial entities ____

Membership Levels:

- ___ \$40 Individual
- ___ \$60 Family (2 adults, children under 18 - list with birthdates)
- ___ \$25 Student/Youth (under 18, or under 23 with student ID)
- ___ Tax Deductible Contribution \$ _____
- ___ Committee Affiliation: *AP__CK__FS__NDK__OCD__OCS__SK__
- ___ \$25 Safety Education and Instruction - SEIC - (Trainers - \$75)
- ___ \$250 Collegiate Partners
- ___ \$225 Organization Affiliates

Payment Options:

Check (payable to "ACA") \$ _____
Credit Card: ___ Visa ___ Discover ___ Mastercard ___ AmEx
Credit Card #: _____ Exp: _____
Name on Card: _____
Signature: _____

*\$5 For Each Committee Affiliation

Adaptive Paddling (AP)/Coastal Kayak (CK)/FreeStyle (FS)/National Downriver Kayak (NDK)/Open Canoe Downriver (OCD)/Open Canoe Slalom (OCS)/Surf Kayak (SK)